

Business

1. Ford's US car sales fell 6.6% year-on-year in the third quarter — a rough stretch by any measure. Despite that drop, what happened to Ford's ranking among US auto sellers?
 - a. It fell to fourth place, overtaken by Hyundai
 - b. It held third place, just ahead of Hyundai
 - c. It rose to second place as rivals stumbled
2. Germany's car industry — home to BMW, Mercedes, and Volkswagen — is fighting for its life against cheaper Chinese rivals. Manufacturers recently made a controversial demand of their workers. What did they ask for?
 - a. A four-day working week to boost morale and productivity
 - b. A move from 35 hours to 40 hours a week with no extra pay
 - c. Voluntary pay cuts in exchange for job security guarantees
3. Burger King has been losing ground to McDonald's and Wendy's for years. As part of its US comeback plan, it recently made a big structural change to how it runs its restaurants. The chain decided to sell hundreds of company-owned restaurants to local operators — a process known as refranchising. Why would a company deliberately sell off its own outlets rather than run them itself?
 - a. To collect upfront cash and shift operating risk onto franchisees who have local knowledge and skin in the game
 - b. To satisfy a US regulatory requirement limiting how many outlets a single food brand can own directly
 - c. To qualify for a tax break available only to companies with fewer than 1,000 directly owned locations
4. Marketing has gone weird. E.l.f. Beauty, Wendy's, and Gap have all recently done something that has nothing to do with their actual products. What have they been up to?
 - a. Releasing original music albums to build brand identity
 - b. Opening pop-up bookshops in major cities to attract footfall
 - c. Sponsoring minor-league cricket teams to reach Gen Z audiences

Economics

5. Eurozone inflation (the rate at which prices across the euro area are rising) jumped to 3.8% in September — a three-year high that came in above most forecasts. What was the main driver of that spike?
 - a. A surge in food prices caused by poor harvests across southern Europe
 - b. Energy prices rising sharply after a period of relative calm
 - c. Wage growth feeding through to higher prices in the services sector

6. Brazilian President Lula recently signed an order banning fixed-odds sports betting just over a week before the first round of the country's presidential election, calling it 'hard, drastic and necessary.' Which of these is NOT a plausible economic reason for banning sports betting platforms?
 - a. Households on low incomes were spending a significant share of wages on betting apps, reducing consumption of essentials
 - b. Betting platforms were inflating Brazil's GDP figures by being counted as financial services exports
 - c. Money was flowing out of the country to foreign-owned betting companies, worsening Brazil's current account (the balance of money coming in and going out)
 7. President Trump recently announced that South Korea would invest \$200 billion in US energy projects, including a \$54 billion liquefied natural gas (LNG) terminal in Alaska. There was one small problem with the announcement. What was it?
 - a. South Korea said it had not actually agreed to invest in the Alaska project
 - b. Alaska's state government said it had not been consulted and opposed the site chosen
 - c. The \$200 billion figure included investments already made over the previous decade
 8. Fuel costs hit people differently depending on where they live. A recent analysis found that filling a 50-litre diesel tank costs a very different share of a worker's monthly wage across Europe. In Bulgaria, the most stretched country, how much of the gross monthly minimum wage does that tank of diesel eat up?
 - a. Around 6%, roughly similar to the European average
 - b. Around 15%, more than four times the rate in Luxembourg
 - c. Around 28%, meaning fuel alone takes more than a quarter of minimum wage
- ### General Knowledge
9. Which country is the world's largest producer of lithium — the metal that sits at the heart of electric vehicle batteries and is sometimes called 'white gold'?
 - a. Chile
 - b. Australia
 - c. China
 10. This 18th-century Scottish economist argued that national wealth came not from hoarding gold but from productive labour and free trade — ideas so influential they still shape economic policy today. Who was he?
 - a. David Hume
 - b. Adam Smith
 - c. Thomas Malthus

Business

1. Ford's US car sales fell 6.6% year-on-year in the third quarter — a rough stretch by any measure. Despite that drop, what happened to Ford's ranking among US auto sellers?

b. Ford held on to third place despite selling 507,395 vehicles — a 6.6% decline. The ranking survived because Hyundai was closing fast but couldn't quite overtake it. It's a useful reminder that relative position and absolute performance can tell very different stories at the same time.

2. Germany's car industry — home to BMW, Mercedes, and Volkswagen — is fighting for its life against cheaper Chinese rivals. Manufacturers recently made a controversial demand of their workers. What did they ask for?

b. German carmakers want workers to extend their week from 35 to 40 hours without additional pay, arguing it's the only way to stay competitive. Unions are strongly opposed. Germany's 35-hour week, won through decades of industrial bargaining, is now a fault line in a sector that employs around 800,000 people directly.

3. Burger King has been losing ground to McDonald's and Wendy's for years. As part of its US comeback plan, it recently made a big structural change to how it runs its restaurants. The chain decided to sell hundreds of company-owned restaurants to local operators — a process known as refranchising. Why would a company deliberately sell off its own outlets rather than run them itself?

a. Refranchising lets Burger King pocket upfront fees, collect ongoing royalties, and hand day-to-day operational headaches to franchisees who tend to run locations more efficiently because their own money is at stake. McDonald's took a similar route decades ago and now owns very few of its restaurants outright — it's essentially a real estate and licensing business.

4. Marketing has gone weird. E.I.f. Beauty, Wendy's, and Gap have all recently done something that has nothing to do with their actual products. What have they been up to?

a. E.I.f. Beauty dropped an album called Mirror Mix, and Wendy's and Gap have joined the trend of brands releasing original music as marketing. The logic: a song can go viral on TikTok in a way a billboard never will, and streaming royalties are a bonus. It's cheaper than a Super Bowl ad and far more shareable.

Economics

5. Eurozone inflation (the rate at which prices across the euro area are rising) jumped to 3.8% in September — a three-year high that came in above most forecasts. What was the main driver of that spike?

b. Energy prices were the primary culprit behind the September spike to 3.8%. After falling for much of 2023 and 2024, energy costs have bounced back — dragging headline inflation (the broadest measure of price changes) higher with them. The European Central Bank will be watching closely, since energy-driven inflation is harder to tame with interest rate rises than wage-driven inflation.

6. Brazilian President Lula recently signed an order banning fixed-odds sports betting just over a week before the first round of the country's presidential election, calling it 'hard, drastic and necessary.' Which of these is NOT a plausible economic reason for banning sports betting platforms?

b. Betting platforms don't meaningfully inflate GDP figures in the way described — that's the implausible option here. The real concerns are very real: Brazilian researchers found that some low-income households were losing meaningful chunks of wages to betting apps, and profits flowing to foreign operators do put pressure on the current account. Several other countries have restricted betting for similar reasons.

7. President Trump recently announced that South Korea would invest \$200 billion in US energy projects, including a \$54 billion liquefied natural gas (LNG) terminal in Alaska. There was one small problem with the announcement. What was it?

a. Seoul said it had not yet agreed to invest in the Alaska LNG project specifically — making the announcement awkward, to put it politely. The broader \$200 billion figure covers various energy deals, but the flagship Alaska project remained unsigned. It fits a pattern of announced investment figures that later require significant clarification when the other party speaks up.

8. Fuel costs hit people differently depending on where they live. A recent analysis found that filling a 50-litre diesel tank costs a very different share of a worker's monthly wage across Europe. In Bulgaria, the most stretched country, how much of the gross monthly minimum wage does that tank of diesel eat up?

b. In Bulgaria, a 50-litre diesel fill costs the equivalent of 15.4% of the gross monthly minimum wage — compared with just 3.8% in Luxembourg. That gap illustrates why energy price spikes hit poorer EU member states so much harder: wages are lower but fuel prices across Europe are broadly similar, so the burden falls disproportionately on those least able to absorb it.

General Knowledge

9. Which country is the world's largest producer of lithium — the metal that sits at the heart of electric vehicle batteries and is sometimes called 'white gold'?

b. Australia is the world's largest lithium producer by volume, accounting for roughly half of global mine output. Chile holds the largest known reserves, sitting on the so-called Lithium Triangle alongside Argentina and Bolivia. China, despite producing far less raw lithium, dominates the refining and processing stage — controlling much of what actually ends up in batteries.

10. This 18th-century Scottish economist argued that national wealth came not from hoarding gold but from productive labour and free trade — ideas so influential they still shape economic policy today. Who was he?

b. Adam Smith published The Wealth of Nations in 1776, the same year as American independence — and arguably just as consequential. His argument that markets, guided by the 'invisible hand' of self-interest, allocate resources better than governments became the foundation of modern capitalism. Smith was also a moral philosopher, and his nuances are often lost when politicians invoke his name.